

Critical Thinking

You now have a process for an AI answer: read it, understand it, validate it, decide how deep to go. **Critical thinking** is where that process comes from, and it's bigger than AI. It works on a chatbot's answer, a TikTok claim, a friend's hot take, a headline. AI makes you faster at both good work and bad work, and the difference is whether you question the output before you use it.

Critical thinking is the habit of not taking information at face value. It is the process of actively analyzing, questioning, and evaluating information, regardless of where it comes from, before deciding what to believe or do.

It isn't "don't trust anything," either. It's the habit of asking what would have to be true for a claim to hold up.

 **Critical thinking isn't new to you.** You already catch weak reasoning in everyday claims without trying. The real skill is running that same check on AI, which is built to sound right.

You just practiced spotting weak reasoning in any claim. These five habits are how you run that instinct on AI output, every time, before you trust it.

CRITICAL THINKING AND AI

There are five habits you can build to sharpen your critical thinking with AI.

The 5 Habits

01 QUESTION THE OUTPUT

Your first instinct: is this actually right?

Don't take the answer at face value. Ask what would have to be true for it to hold up.

02 KNOW YOUR LIMITS

If you can't evaluate it, you're flying blind.

Remember Maria Petronoski's three gold medals? Perfectly plausible, completely made up. The further the topic is from what you know, the more carefully you have to verify, and that's exactly when AI feels most authoritative.

03 WHAT'S MISSING?

AI tells you what it knows. Not what it left out.

Look for context, exceptions, perspectives, and counterarguments the answer skipped.

04 DON'T AUTO-TRUST IT

Confident isn't the same as correct.

The smoother the answer reads, the more your guard drops. That pull is the thing to catch.

05 KEEP OWNERSHIP

You decide what to keep, change, or toss.

AI generates options. The thinking, the call, and the consequences are yours.

 **AI amplifies whatever you bring to it.** Good thinking in, sharper output. Lazy thinking in, polished mediocrity. The model doesn't fix your thinking. It scales it.

There's one more level to this. Every habit on this list gets easier when you know what the machine on the other side is actually doing, because you can't be fooled by something you understand. That's exactly where this course goes next.